

THE MICHAEL THORNE SERIES - BOOK THREE

The Ascendants

A Psychological Crime Thriller

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READING SAMPLE

Formatted edition

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About this reading sample

This reading sample contains a continuous excerpt from the beginning of *The Ascendants*. It is based on the edition identified on the cover. The text below is drawn from the manuscript and is not the complete book.

Excerpt length: approximately 4,531 words.

PROLOGUE

THE CASE THE LAW REFUSED

* * *

Paul Rourke arrived at the Halliday Foundation Conference Facility at 8:41 on Monday night.

The federal search had ended less than two hours earlier.

Yellow evidence tape still crossed the third-floor corridor.

A private security guard lifted it for him.

The guard did not ask for identification.

Rourke noticed that before he noticed Raymond Halliday waiting at the far end of the conference room.

Twenty-three chairs remained around the long table.

The brass nameplate bearing Michael Thorne's name had been removed by federal agents.

A pale rectangle marked where it had rested.

Halliday sat three places to the right of the empty head chair.

Not in it.

Rourke removed his coat but kept it over one arm.

He was sixty-three, broad through the chest and slower in the left knee than he had been when he carried a badge.

He had spent nineteen years telling himself that retirement had ended the need to watch doors.

The room proved otherwise.

"You said you had the original ballistics report," Rourke said.

Halliday placed one hand on a closed file.

"I said I had what the law refused to consider."

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

Halliday's hair had gone completely white.

His suit was dark enough to look black beneath the fluorescent lights.

Nothing about him resembled the men Rourke remembered from tavern meetings, courthouse corridors and police foundation dinners.

Age had removed the need to appear accidental.

"Open it," Halliday said.

Rourke remained standing.

"Federal agents searched this room today."

"They searched the furniture and the network. They did not search the history."

"They have a warrant for you."

"They have several."

"Then why are you here?"

Halliday looked towards the sealed windows.

The river beyond them reflected office lights in broken vertical lines.

"Because you came."

Rourke should have left.

He had entered through a controlled lobby using a visitor credential delivered by Halliday's attorney.

His phone showed service.

His wife knew he was meeting a lawyer about an old complaint.

Every precaution had been selected to make departure feel available.

That was why he did not trust it.

He sat opposite Halliday and opened the file.

The first page carried a name he had not spoken aloud in years.

DESHAWN BELL.

Age at death: seventeen.

Date: February 14, 2004.

Location: service alley behind a closed pharmacy on West Madison.

The photograph showed a teenager lying beside a dumpster with one arm beneath his body.

A revolver rested near his right hand.

The weapon had been clean when Rourke placed it there.

Snow had not yet reached the grip.

Rourke closed the file.

"You do not have the report."

"Continue."

"I know what is in it."

"You know what survived."

Rourke opened the file again.

A witness statement followed.

Ava Mercer, twenty-two at the time, had seen an officer fire from the alley mouth.

Her first interview identified Thomas Kroll.

Her second identified Rourke.

Her third said she could no longer distinguish either man.
The final affidavit stated she had not seen the shooting.
Rourke read the signature.
It was hers.
The fear had been someone else's.
The next page was an Internal Affairs memorandum.
Prepared by Detective David Wells.
Finding:

CLOSURE WITHOUT EXONERATION.

The phrase had infuriated the command staff.
It had also kept the complaint from becoming a finding of innocence.
Rourke touched the corner of the page.
"Wells did not clear me."
"He closed the case."
"Because Ava recanted and the bullet disappeared."
"The law refused."
"The law was made blind."
Halliday leaned back.
"By you."
Rourke looked at him.
"I planted the gun. I did not shoot the boy."
"A distinction useful to the man who planted the gun."
"And to the truth."
"Truth without consequence becomes biography."
Rourke stood.

The guard near the door did not move.

"You told her employer," Rourke said.

Halliday's expression remained unchanged.

"You had Ava fired. You had her mother's lease reviewed.
You put two men outside the hospital when her son was born."

"Can you prove that?"

"Not then."

"And now?"

Rourke looked at the file.

"The ballistics report can."

Halliday placed a second document beside it.

Not a report.

A single-page assessment.

PAUL EDWARD ROURKE.

Central allegation:

INTENTIONAL HOMICIDE OF DESHAWN BELL.

Below the statement were three boxes.

NOT GUILTY.

INSUFFICIENT.

At the bottom:

CANDIDATE DECISION PENDING.

Rourke read it twice.

"Thorne never saw this."

"Not yet."

"You expect a prisoner to decide whether I live."

"I expect a man who understands institutional failure to recognise a case."

"Michael Thorne murdered Harold Hale while Hale was in custody."

"Yes."

"That makes him your leader?"

"It makes refusal difficult to distinguish from qualification."

Rourke pushed the assessment back.

"Mark insufficient."

Halliday looked at him.

"Why?"

"Because I am guilty of what I did. Not what you wrote."

"The boy remained dead."

"Thomas Kroll shot him."

"Kroll is dead."

"Then your correction arrived twenty-two years too late."

Halliday's eyes moved towards the empty head chair.

"Correction does not expire because the first offender does."

"No. It changes targets until someone agrees to call revenge procedure."

The guard near the door stepped forward.

Rourke reached inside his coat.

The guard's hand moved beneath his jacket.

Rourke removed a small brass key and placed it on the table.

"Ava gave me that after the complaint closed."

Halliday looked at the key but did not touch it.

"What does it open?"

"Something you failed to find."

"Where?"

"That is what you wanted me to say."

Rourke picked up the Internal Affairs memorandum and folded it once.

The paper was a copy.

No evidentiary value by itself.

Enough to carry a name.

"Tell Thorne Wells was right," he said.

"About what?"

"Closure is not exoneration."

Halliday's expression changed.

Not anger.

Recognition that Rourke had spoken to the empty chair as though it held a person Halliday did not control.

The guard crossed the distance.

Rourke turned.

A second man entered through the service door behind him.

No mask.

No attempt to preserve mystery.

A clear plastic injector rested in his right hand.

Rourke struck the first guard with the file.

Paper opened across the table.

The photograph of DeShawn Bell slid beneath the empty head chair.

The second man drove the injector into Rourke's shoulder.

Rourke reached for him and caught only fabric.

The room moved sideways.

Halliday remained seated.

"You could have presented the key voluntarily," he said.

Rourke tried to speak.

His tongue became heavier than the sentence.

The fluorescent lights divided into white bars.

The last thing he saw in the room was Halliday lifting the ballot without marking any box.

Rourke regained consciousness inside a prisoner transport van.

Metal bench.

Perforated partition.

No windows in the rear compartment.

His wrists were cuffed to a floor rail.

His coat was gone.

Cold entered through the steel before he understood where the van had been left.

The engine was off.

No ventilation fan.

A faint public-address announcement reached him through the walls.

Daley Center loading area.

Close enough to the courthouse for discovery to look like judgment.

Far enough from the public entrance for the night to do the work.

Rourke pulled against the cuffs.

The sedative had weakened his right arm.

His left hand still held the folded Internal Affairs memorandum.

Someone had allowed him to keep it.

Or had not noticed.

He worked the paper between his fingers until the line with Wells's name separated from the rest.

The strip tore unevenly.

CLOSURE WITHOUT EXONERATION.

D. WELLS.

Rourke closed his hand around it.

He kicked the rear door.

Once.

The sound disappeared into the insulated shell.

He kicked again.

No answer.

The cold reduced the room to measurable losses.

Feeling in his fingers.

Strength in the leg.

Time between breaths.

He thought of Ava Mercer at twenty-two, trying to describe an officer she had seen beneath a broken security light.

He had called her unreliable because the alternative required him to name Kroll and himself in the same account.

Halliday had not invented his guilt.

He had compressed it until only the allegation useful for punishment remained.

Rourke understood why Michael Thorne might recognise the method.

That did not make Michael necessary.

It made the method older than either man.

Rourke struck the door a third time.

This time, someone outside stopped walking.

A shadow passed beneath the rear seal.

The handle moved.

Not enough.

A voice called for security.

Rourke kept his fist closed around Wells's memorandum.

When the doors opened, winter air entered first.

CHAPTER 1

THE FIRST CASE

* * *

The transport van was discovered at 5:42 on Tuesday morning.

A courthouse maintenance worker heard metal striking metal in the service bay beneath the Daley Center.

By the time security opened the rear compartment, Paul Rourke was unconscious.

He died forty-three minutes later at Northwestern Memorial Hospital.

Elena arrived after the body.

Her protective detail stopped two vehicles behind the crime-scene van and waited while Special Agent Priya Desai verified the perimeter.

The service bay smelled of exhaust, wet concrete and road salt.

Black snow had collected around the drains where delivery trucks carried it inside.

The van stood beneath a fluorescent strip that flickered every six seconds.

Not theatrical.

Poor maintenance documented in three earlier work orders.

A Cook County transport emblem remained on both side panels.

The vehicle had been retired nine years earlier and purchased at auction by Halliday Protective Services.

Its current registration belonged to a shell company with no employees.

"Time of death?" Elena asked.

The medical examiner's investigator looked up from the open rear doors.

"Preliminary only. Core temperature was seventy-nine point eight at admission. Sedative exposure likely contributed. No obvious lethal trauma."

"Hypothermia?"

"Consistent. We will know after autopsy."

Desai stood beside the evidence photographer.

She wore a charcoal overcoat with a white salt line drying along the hem.

"Rourke was one of the twenty-three case subjects," she said.

"Not a package recipient."

"Correct."

"How did he enter the building?"

"The van used a one-time loading credential issued at 10:14 last night. Request originated from a Halliday Protective Services account. The courthouse system accepted it because the company still holds an emergency transport contract."

"Driver?"

"Camera caught a cap and surgical mask. Height and build only."

"Vehicle tracker?"

"Removed before the van entered the bay."

Elena approached the rear compartment without crossing the evidence line.

The metal bench carried no restraints beyond the floor rail.

Rourke's right cuff remained attached.

The left had been cut by paramedics.

A folded hospital blanket lay near the partition.

It had not been placed over him.

The interior temperature when security opened the doors had been nineteen degrees Fahrenheit.

The van was not refrigerated.

Chicago had been sufficient.

"Any message?" Elena asked.

Desai pointed towards a small evidence marker beside the bench.

A strip of paper rested beneath clear plastic.

CLOSURE WITHOUT EXONERATION.

D. WELLS.

Elena read it without moving closer.

"Did he write it?"

"Unknown. It was in his right hand. The paper matches an Internal Affairs memo from 2005."

"David's memo?"

"Yes."

Wells had been moved to a federal safe apartment after Halliday's three-name list was recovered.

His protection team had not told him about Rourke.

Not yet.

"What was the case?" Elena asked.

Desai handed her a scene summary.

The top page showed DeShawn Bell's school photograph.

Seventeen years old.

Killed in 2004.

A revolver found beside him.

Officer Paul Rourke named in an initial witness statement.

Complaint closed after the witness recanted and ballistic evidence could not be located.

Elena looked towards the van.

"Halliday called this a case the law refused."

"That is the working connection."

"Working, not verified."

"Yes."

Desai's phone vibrated.

She read the message.

"Autopsy priority approved. We will have toxicology screening within hours."

"Was Rourke under surveillance?"

"Federal team placed him on the review list after the conference room search. He was contacted at 8:12 last night. He declined voluntary protection."

"By whom?"

"An agent spoke to him directly. Rourke said he was home and would meet counsel in the morning."

"Was he home?"

"His phone was."

The pattern did not require a forged identity.

It required a person to leave the device that represented him.

"Halliday contacted him?"

"We have not found the call. His wife says Rourke left at eight twenty-five to meet an attorney about an old complaint."

"Name?"

"He did not give one."

The evidence technician photographed the van's interior ceiling.

A round camera mount remained above the rear door.

No camera.

Two clean screw heads showed recent removal.

"Halliday recorded him," Elena said.

Desai followed her gaze.

"Likely."

"For Michael?"

"Possible."

Elena looked at her.

"Or for the recipients. Or himself. We do not make Michael the audience until the evidence does."

"Agreed."

The crime-scene supervisor approached with a sealed clear bag.

Inside lay a brass key attached to a paper tag.

No address.

A stamped number:

318.

"Found in the conference facility elevator," he said.

"Cleaning staff turned it over after the federal search. They found it beneath the control panel at six this morning."

"Connection to Rourke?" Desai asked.

"His right thumbprint is on the tag. Halliday's print is not in the comparison database."

The key had left Rourke before he entered the van.

Or after.

The timing remained unknown.

"What does it open?" Elena asked.

"Commercial cylinder. Older design. Locker, storage cage, maybe a desk."

Desai ordered an emergency search through municipal storage registries and private facilities tied to Rourke, DeShawn Bell and Ava Mercer.

The last name produced a current address in Milwaukee and a Chicago attorney who had represented Mercer during the Internal Affairs review.

The attorney had died in 2017.

His office files had been transferred to a records warehouse.

Unit number:

318.

The warrant application began before the van left the service bay.

At 7:08, Wells joined by secure video from the protected apartment.

He saw only the paper strip, the 2005 case number and Rourke's name.

No photograph of the body.

No scene interpretation.

Desai activated the recording.

"Do you recognise the language?"

"Yes," Wells said.

"Did you write it?"

"Yes."

"Explain."

Wells looked towards someone outside his camera frame.

His attorney.

Then back at the lens.

"Closure without exoneration was an Internal Affairs disposition used when evidence did not support a sustained finding but the investigation left material concerns unresolved. Command discouraged the wording because it prevented a clean personnel conclusion."

"Did you apply it to Paul Rourke?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"The witness recanted. The recovered weapon carried no usable prints. The bullet removed at autopsy was transferred to the firearms laboratory and then disappeared from the evidence log. We could not establish Rourke fired the shot."

"Did you believe he did?"

Wells did not answer with certainty he had never possessed.

"I believed Rourke participated in staging the scene."

"Evidence?"

"Snow distribution around the revolver. The weapon was placed after Bell fell. Rourke's initial report described it beneath the right hand. Scene photographs showed it six inches beyond the fingers."

"Why was that not charged?"

"The photographs were challenged because the original timestamp file was corrupted. The state's attorney declined."

"Did Rourke admit planting the gun?"

"Not to me."

"Did you know Thomas Kroll?"

Wells became still.

"Yes."

"Role?"

"Second officer on scene. Not listed in the first dispatch summary."

"Possible shooter?"

"Possible."

"Why does the official complaint identify Rourke?"

"Because Ava Mercer identified him in her second interview."

"And her first?"

Wells looked directly at Desai.

"Kroll."

Elena wrote the sequence.

First Kroll.

Then Rourke.

Then neither.

Then no observation.

Not inconsistency by itself.

A history of pressure.

"Did Halliday appear in the file?" Desai asked.

"Not by name. A police foundation representative attended Mercer's third interview as a community liaison. The sign-in sheet used the initials R.H."

"Did you investigate?"

"I requested foundation visitor records. The request was denied as outside scope."

"By whom?"

"Deputy Superintendent Raymond Halliday."

The name entered as a documented act.

Not proof of murder.

Enough to change the case.

Wells continued before Desai asked.

"I need to be recused from the Rourke homicide."

"You are a potential fact witness," she said.

"And Halliday selected my memo as part of the scene."

"Agreed. You may provide historical evidence through counsel. No access to active strategy."

Wells nodded.

He did not argue that familiarity made him necessary.

Elena noticed because Michael would have.

The comparison did not make either man the standard for the other.

At 8:26, the autopsy began.

At 8:40, a local television station received an anonymous email containing a scan of Rourke's closed complaint.

Subject line:

THE FIRST CASE.

The station contacted police before publication.

The email included no body photograph.

No confession.

No demand.

One sentence appeared beneath the attachment.

THE LAW CLOSED WHAT IT COULD NOT CLEAN.

Digital tracing led to a public wireless access point inside the Halliday Foundation building.

The message had been scheduled before Rourke died.

Halliday did not need confirmation of death to call the case complete.

He needed the process to begin.

At 9:03, the judge signed the warrant for records unit 318.

Elena and Desai travelled with the evidence team.

The warehouse stood beneath CTA tracks in West Loop.

Each passing train moved dust from the steel beams and shook the locked glass door.

The manager opened the unit from a distance after verifying the warrant twice.

Locker 318 contained six archive boxes.

One portable cassette recorder.

A sealed evidence envelope marked with DeShawn Bell's case number.

And a framed photograph of Raymond Halliday standing beside Ava Mercer outside the Internal Affairs building in 2005.

Halliday's hand rested on her shoulder.

Ava's face showed no injury.

Fear did not require one.

Inside the evidence envelope was an undeveloped strip of ballistic film and a handwritten note from Paul Rourke.

**IF THEY KILL ME AS THE SHOOTER, FIND THE
MAN WHO TAUGHT THE WITNESS TO
CHANGE.**

Beneath it:

WELLS WAS RIGHT ABOUT THE CLOSURE.

**HE WAS WRONG ABOUT WHO CONTROLLED
IT.**

CHAPTER 2

CLOSURE WITHOUT EXONERATION

* * *

Ava Mercer agreed to speak only after Elena promised not to call her protected.

"People use that word when they have already decided where I should go," Ava said through the attorney's video line.

She was forty-four now.

Her hair had been cut close to the scalp.

A narrow apartment kitchen appeared behind her, bright with morning light and children's drawings held to a refrigerator by magnets.

No attempt had been made to hide the life surrounding the witness.

"You can decline the interview," Elena said. "You can choose counsel. You can choose location."

"Can I choose not to move?"

"Yes."

"Even if you think Halliday is coming?"

"We can recommend security without removing you."

Ava looked away from the screen.

Her attorney, a public-interest lawyer in Milwaukee, remained visible beside her.

"Paul is dead," Ava said.

"Yes."

"Did he tell you he shot DeShawn?"

"No."

"Then do not say the case was about whether he was innocent."

Elena waited.

Ava turned back.

"He put the gun beside DeShawn. He signed the report. He watched Kroll tell DeShawn to stop moving while blood filled his jacket. Paul did not fire. He made the killing usable."

The distinction matched Rourke's final claim.

Not exoneration.

A different form of guilt.

"Why did you identify Rourke in the second interview?" Elena asked.

Ava's expression hardened.

"Because Raymond Halliday showed me a photograph of my mother leaving work."

"During the interview?"

"Before. In the corridor. He said witnesses sometimes mistook the face nearest the body for the face holding the weapon. Then he asked whether my mother still rented month to month."

"Did he threaten her directly?"

"He did not need to."

"Who attended the second interview?"

"Rourke. Two Internal Affairs detectives. A foundation lawyer. Halliday came in and out."

"David Wells?"

"Not until the third."

"What happened before the third?"

Ava touched the edge of the table.

"My mother received an eviction notice. My employer said police had called about theft. Two men followed me to the prenatal clinic."

"Were you pregnant?"

"Seven months."

"Did Rourke contact you privately?"

"After the complaint closed."

"What did he say?"

"That he had done the wrong thing for a man who had done worse."

"Kroll?"

"Yes."

"Did he give you the key to unit 318?"

Ava looked towards her attorney.

"He gave it to my old lawyer. I did not know where it was until last night."

"Last night?"

"Paul called."

Elena did not interrupt.

The call had not appeared in Rourke's primary phone record.

"What number?"

"Blocked. He said Halliday had invited him to see the original report. He said if he did not call by ten, I should tell Wells the closure was not the failure."

"What was?"

"Letting Halliday stay outside the file."

"Why did you not call police?"

Ava's anger became quieter.

"Which part? The police officer who planted the gun? The deputy superintendent who threatened my mother? The Internal Affairs unit that wrote a careful sentence and closed the door?"

Elena accepted the question without defending the institution.

"Why speak now?"

"Because Paul died saying he was not the shooter. That is true. If it becomes the only truth, DeShawn disappears again."

The statement defined the interview.

Ava would not be used to simplify Rourke into victim or offender.

"We recovered ballistic film," Elena said. "It has not been developed or authenticated."

"Rourke said Kroll's revolver fired the bullet."

"Did you see Kroll fire?"

"Yes."

"Where was Rourke?"

"Near the squad car. He came into the alley after the shot."

"Did DeShawn have a weapon?"

"No."

Ava's attorney placed a hand near the microphone.

"We need a break."

"Agreed," Elena said.

The video paused.

Desai stood inside the federal interview room beside a wall map of Milwaukee.

A protection team waited two blocks from Ava's apartment.

No visible vehicles outside the building.

No order to move her.

"Halliday's case file accused Rourke of the shooting," Desai said.

"Because the stronger false allegation absorbs the true lesser conduct."

"Murder makes the gun planting disappear."

"And killing him prevents a trial where both can be separated."

Desai looked towards the paused image.

"Ava is the person who can uncompress the case."

"Which makes her a target."

The federal protection supervisor entered without knocking.

"Milwaukee County just transmitted an emergency mental-health transport order for Ava Mercer."

Elena stood.

"Basis?"

"Reported suicidal intent and access to a firearm."

"Source?"

"Anonymous clinical referral attached to a sealed affidavit."

"Judge?"

"Real signature. Entered twelve minutes ago."

"Has the team moved?"

"They are holding position. A county public-health van is approaching the building."

Desai activated the incident recorder.

"No extraction. Confirm with the issuing judge through a known channel. Notify local police that federal witnesses are present."

"Ava is not formally a federal witness yet," the supervisor said.

"Then describe an active homicide investigation and risk of impersonation. Do not create status we do not have."

Elena reconnected the video.

Ava and her attorney had moved away from the table.

Someone knocked at the apartment door.

Three measured strikes.

A male voice identified Milwaukee County Behavioral Health.

Ava looked at the screen.

"You promised I could choose not to move."

"Do not open the door," Elena said.

"They have an order."

"We are verifying it. Your attorney is present. Ask them to wait."

The lawyer approached the door without unlatching it.

"Please slide the order beneath the door."

Paper appeared across the floor.

The document carried the correct county seal.

A current judge's signature.

A case number generated by the clerk's system.

No spelling error.

No invented agency.

The affidavit stated Ava had threatened to kill herself if police reopened the Bell shooting.

The attached quotation came from the confidential video interview that had begun twenty-six minutes earlier.

A sentence Ava had not spoken.

The system had not only found her.

Someone had access to the existence of the interview before the recording left the room.

"Who knew we were speaking?" Elena asked.

Desai counted.

Federal case team.

Ava's attorney.

Milwaukee protection supervisor.

The court liaison who arranged the secure video.

No public filing.

No docket.

The voice outside changed.

"Ms. Mercer, failure to comply may result in physical removal."

Ava looked towards her attorney.

"That sounds like protection."

Elena heard the accusation and did not contest it.

"Your lawyer can challenge the order before entry. Local police are arriving."

The attorney spoke through the door.

"Name and licence number of the evaluating clinician."

The man outside gave both.

The clinician existed.

She was working in another county and had not signed the affidavit.

Desai's phone lit with confirmation from the judge.

He had signed the order after receiving a call from a person identifying herself as a federal prosecutor.

The caller provided the active homicide case number and a sealed excerpt from Ava's 2005 psychiatric intake.

The intake was real.

It had been created after Halliday's pressure campaign.

Old harm had been converted into current authority.

"Local officers at the stairwell," the supervisor said.

The public-health team attempted to leave.

The driver reached the rear exit before federal agents stopped him.

His name was Calvin Rees.

Fifty-two.

Former Cook County deputy sheriff.

Current subcontractor for Halliday Protective Services.

The passenger was a licensed emergency medical technician who believed the order was valid.

The van contained soft restraints, two sedative kits and a sealed transfer packet.

Destination:

LINDEN BEHAVIORAL ASSESSMENT ANNEX.

The address belonged to an office building emptied during the continuation investigation.

No clinical staff remained there.

Inside Rees's jacket, agents found a folded case sheet.

AVA MERCER.

Status:

UNRELIABLE WITNESS.

Corrective objective:

REMOVE CONTRADICTORY TESTIMONY FROM SUCCESSOR REVIEW.

No instruction to kill her.

No need.

A locked clinical transfer could remove a witness from the case long enough for Halliday to publish his verdict.

Rees requested an attorney.

The EMT gave a statement immediately.

She had accepted the shift through a county staffing portal.

The pay rate was ordinary.

The order looked genuine.

Her participation was not proof of allegiance.

Elena returned to the video after the hallway cleared.

Ava remained inside her apartment.

Her attorney had placed a chair beneath the door handle despite the officers outside.

"Do you still want the interview?" Elena asked.

Ava looked at the copy of the transport order on the floor.

"Yes."

"We can stop."

"That is what the order was for."

The interview resumed with a new chain-of-custody record and a separate attorney acknowledgement.

Ava described the shooting.

Kroll shouting.

DeShawn raising empty hands.

The shot.

Rourke arriving.

The revolver removed from an evidence bag and placed near the body.

Halliday standing beyond the alley tape twenty minutes later, not as command officer, but as representative of a police foundation that had no official reason to be there.

The developed ballistic film confirmed part of her account by noon.

The rifling marks matched Thomas Kroll's service revolver.

The weapon had been destroyed after Kroll's death under a routine disposal order signed by Halliday.

Rourke was not exonerated.

He had staged the scene.

Halliday's central allegation was false.

His correction had killed a guilty man for the wrong crime and attempted to erase the witness who could explain the difference.

At 1:18, Desai received a court-authorised copy of an email sent to Michael's legal-mail account.

No attachment.

One question.

WHEN THE LAW REFUSES A GUILTY MAN BECAUSE IT CANNOT NAME THE CORRECT GUILT, WHAT SHOULD REPLACE IT?

Halliday had not asked Michael whether Rourke deserved to die.

He had asked whether Michael still believed private judgment was the only answer to institutional failure.

The question reached the detention hospital before the ballistic film reached the case file.

Halliday already knew which truth would emerge.

Continue reading

You have reached the end of this reading sample from *The Ascendants*. The complete work continues beyond this excerpt.

The Michael Thorne Series - Book Three